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Colonial State, Agrarian Transition and Popular Protest in Orissa, 1921–1947

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Colonial State, Agrarian Transition and Popular Protest in Orissa, 1921–1947, by Susanta Kumar Bag, Delhi, Primus Books, 2015, xiv + 191 pp., 995 Rupees (paperback), ISBN-13: 978-93-84082-25-3

This book examines peasant protest in colonial Orissa in course of the three mass movements leading to the process of decolonization. The author begins by telling us about the 'paradoxical rediscovery of peasants' over the 1960s and 1970s. This sarcastic punch is not explained, though we are told that this had led to a 'flood of publications explicitly devoted to peasants from a few hundreds to thousands' over this phase (1). Christopher Hill had previously suggested how movements of people stimulated intellectual and creative activity. If seen in this way the context and the post-1945 setting perhaps explain the basis of this 'flood of publications'. After all, this period witnessed the success of the anti-colonial, liberation movements in India and China; the Telengana and the Naxalbari movement in post-colonial India; the triumph of the Cuban Revolution (1959); the student movement in France (1968); and the resistance faced by US imperialism in Vietnam. In fact, all these stirred the interest of scholars, intellectuals and academics in both western and non-western societies and made them focus on the peasantry. One can therefore perhaps argue that the author's work rediscovers an area that has gone though its ups and downs, even as it retains its relevance in the 'Republic of Hunger' (viz. India) where, according to serious estimates, more than 25,000 peasants have been driven to commit suicide since 1997.

In the introduction, the author weaves in the historiography of peasant protest in colonial India, and also in Orissa. He refers to the three trends – imperialist, nationalist and Marxist historiography (3) –,and also to Ranjit Guha (Ranajit Guha) and the 'subaltern' school of historians, all of whom are painted with a single brush. In the first chapter Bag discusses the colonial economy and its nuances in the context of Orissa. The logic of economic determinism is boldly asserted: 'The primary issue or demands around which the peasant movements took place during nineteenth- and twentieth-century India was the government's taxation policy' (2). This is contradicted by the author's reference to *bethi* (forced labour) a little later. After all, was not forced labour resisted *also* because it undermined human dignity and the identity of the recruits?

Next the author discusses the nature of the agrarian system in the context of Orissa's colonial under-development. The agrarian interventions, the shifts and changes and certain specificities in the coastal tract are captured rather effectively. And talking about certain specificities, Bag refers to the domination of Brahmins as landlords, some of whom were also associated with money-lending, co-existing with a very high level of rural indebtedness, which saw about 75 per cent of peasants remaining in debt in the Cuttack district in 1893. He also throws light on the princely states, Sambalpur and the Jeypur zamindari. The basic idea here is to illustrate the narrowing down of the gap between the emerging middle class and the world of the peasants. It is against this canvas that some of the nineteenth-century peasant rebellions are discussed, though the author does not refer to the shifts and changes in the nature of the peasant movements. One needs to appreciate Bag's effort to steer clear of cultural symbols that are streamrollered, homogenized and connected – rather unhistorically – by some scholars with peasant and tribal consciousness. Nevertheless, he transgresses basic facts and boldly asserts that Madhusudan Das advocated the abolition of landlordism (32) in the early years of the twentieth century on the basis of a biographer's writing (Surendra Mohanty, *Madhusudan Das* (New Delhi, 1972)). Such formulations to romanticize the Oriya middle class are unfortunate. After this the author discusses the national movement in Orissa to explain the way in which he has planned this work.

The next four chapters focus on the 'Non-Cooperation Movement' (1921–2); the 'Salt Satyagraha' (1928–34); the 'Kisan Sabha (Peasant Organization) and the Peoples' Movement in the princely states'; and the '1942 Movement'. Unfortunately, we are not told anything new

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about these movements and most of what is delineated is a narrative that would seem to be very familiar to anyone who has some idea about the goings on in colonial Orissa over this period. In any case, the sudden appearance of the 'aboriginal tenants' in Mayurbhanj (in 1925–7) (63) or the 'aboriginal tribals' in Nilgiri (in 1947) (162) pose serious complications. Besides the fact that we are not told anything about the *adivasis* (i.e. tribals) who formed a major part of the three mass movements in the introduction, such articulations crudely echo colonial anthropology.

A major shortcoming of the book is that it is full of references and ideas drawn from secondary sources, which are sometimes not even acknowledged, like some parts of the conclusion. Some other problems include ignoring areas that undermine the nationalist argument that the author is seeking to put in place. Thus, he locates the Congress-inspired movement mono-dimensionally. Consequently, the pluralities and tensions related to the development of the mass movements in Orissa hardly receive any space. A typical example is the policy of 'non-interference' in the princely states that had been advocated by Gandhi, and which made the Congress initially prevaricate in the context of the development of major popular struggles in some of the princely states (1938). The fetter of nationalist historiography is sought to be disguised by focusing on the resignation of the Congress ministry (1939). Similarly, Bag does not engage with a core area related to the abolition of the zamindari system that had been raised by the Orissa Kisan Sangha. This theme figures in the conclusion as an unresolved component in the context of decolonization. Moreover, reading the book it appears as if problems like communalism were external to Orissa, and caste did not matter when it came to the movements that are discussed.

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The Left Side of History: World War II and the unfulfilled promise of communism in eastern Europe, by Kristen Ghodsee, Durham, NC and London, Duke University Press, 2015, xx + 231 pp., £55.00/$84.9 (hardback), £15.99/$23.95 (paperback), ISBN-13: 978-0-8223-5835-0

The Left Side of History is an ambitious book. It is a biography of a young man and woman who served in the Bulgarian partisan movement during the Second World War; it is a profile of ageing activists of the communist-era Bulgarian Women's Committee; it is an attack on what Ghodsee views as the 'blackwashing' of the communist past in contemporary eastern Europe; and above all, it is a moving investigation into how communism shaped individual lives from the 1940s through to the present. Ghodsee's book is not a typical academic work; in the introduction, she cautions that it is 'not a conventional history or a traditional ethnography' (xix). Her arguments are directed primarily at politicians and journalists in eastern Europe (and, to a lesser extent, the United States), whom she sees as responsible for distorting the legacy of communism. *The Left Side of History* is also not a typical academic book in so far as it is highly readable, and at times hard to put down.

The book's first section interweaves the biographies of two fighters in Bulgaria's partisan movement: Frank Thompson and Elena Lagadinova. Thompson was born into an upper-class English family (he was the older brother of the historian E. P. Thompson). An aspiring poet with a passion for foreign languages, he attended Oxford University, where he fell in love with the